KEYNOTE ADDRESS AT THE 38TH ANNUAL CONVENTION OF THE CANON LAW SOCIETY OF NIGERIA & 95TH BIRTHDAY CELEBRATION OF OUR FOUNDER, MOST REV. ANTHONY O. GBUJI

Theme: "Canon Law and Clerical Political Engagement in Nigeria: Ensuring Ecclesial Unity, Mission, and Credibility"

Venue: Holy Ghost Cathedral, Enugu

Date: 27th – 30th October, 2026

Your Excellency, Most Rev. C.V.C Onaga,

Our revered Father and Founder, Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji, whom we celebrate at 95,

Your Excellency, the Governor of Enugu State, Barr. (Dr.) Peter Ndubisi Mbah,

Monsignores,

Very Rev. Fr Edwin Omoregbe, President of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria,

Distinguished Officers and Members of the Society,

Priests and Consecrated Persons,

Legal Luminaries, the Lay Faithful,

Ladies and Gentlemen.

1. INTRODUCTION

I am deeply honored to stand before this distinguished assembly of canonists, as Bishop Chairman for Canon Law, of the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria, (CBCN) the Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu and Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki Diocese, to deliver this keynote at a moment of double joy – 38 years of this Society's service to law and order in the Church, and 95 years of a life that taught us to love that law, in the person of Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji.

To you, My Lord Bishop Gbuji, our father, on behalf of the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria, we say *Ad multos et faustissimos annos*! You planted a mustard seed when you founded this Society, and today it is a tree providing shade for the Church in Nigeria.

Our theme is not theoretical. It is urgent, pastoral, and delicate: **Canon Law and Clerical Political Engagement in Nigeria**. In a nation where a careless statement from the pulpit can divide a

community, and where silence in the face of injustice can betray the Gospel, we must ask: What does the Law say, and how must we obey it?

2. THE CLEAR TEACHING OF THE CHURCH AND THE CBCN ON THIS TOPIC

Let me begin by stating the position of the Church with canonical clarity, without ambiguity. The Universal Law is clear. Can. 287 §2 states: ***"They are not to have an active part in political parties and in governing labor unions unless, in the judgment of competent ecclesiastical authority, the protection of the rights of the Church or the promotion of the common good requires it."*** This is reinforced by Can. 285 §3 and Can. 672 for religious.

On this foundation, **the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria strictly forbids Catholic priests and members of Institutes of Consecrated Life from engaging in active, partisan politics and from holding public office without proper Church permission.**

This is not an advice. It is a binding directive. What does this mean in practice? It means that no cleric or religious is permitted to do the following:

a) Contest for elective office,

b) Accept appointment to a partisan political office,

c) Serve as a party chieftain, spokesperson, or campaign manager,

d) Mount a political podium to endorse a candidate or party.

The reason is theological: The priest is ordained for all. *He is father of all*. The moment he wears the jersey of a party; he loses moral authority to father those in the opposing party. The altar must never become a campaign podium.

3. BUT, WHY THIS PROHIBITION?

This prohibition exists in order to PROTECT THREE PILLARS: **Ecclesial Unity, Mission, and Credibility**.

For Unity: Partisanship divides the parish. When a priest endorses a candidate, half his parish feels alienated. The bishop's voice, and the CBCN's voice, must be the united voice of the Church, not a discordance of individual political preferences.

For Mission: Our mission is to form consciences, not to dictate candidates. The Church's political engagement is prophetic, not partisan. We must proclaim principles – sanctity of life, justice, religious freedom, common good – and form the lay faithful, whose proper vocation by Can. 225 §2 is to animate the political order.

For Credibility: Nothing destroys the credibility of the Church faster than a priest who becomes a political sycophant, and whose candidate later fails or is found corrupt. The people then say, "The Church is like them".

4. THEERE ARE S CONSEQUENCES OF VIOLATION OF VIOLATION OF THIS LAW

My dear canonists, a law without a sanction is mere counsel. The Church takes this matter seriously. I wish to state unequivocally that **violations of these canonical directives on partisan politics carry strict disciplinary measures enforced by the CBCN and by individual Ordinaries.**

In line with the norms of Can. 1311-1399 on penal law, and the particular law of our Conference, sanctions ranging from **canonical warning, to suspension from public ministry, to withdrawal of faculties, and in grave, obstinate cases, to the process of dismissal from the clerical state**, may be applied. These penalties are not to be seen as vindictive. They are medicinal and protective. It is to protect the faithful from scandal, to protect the priest from self-destruction, and to protect the Church's mission. No one is above the law, and obedience is the hallmark of true ministry. However, any cleric who feels, **in conscience,** that an exceptional situation as foreseen in Can. 287 §2 requires his active political involvement must follow the canonical path: **write to his Bishop, seek permission from competent authority, and act under obedience. Permission is never presumed**.

5. CONCLUSION: FROM PULPIT POLITICS TO FORMATION POLITICS

At 95, Bishop Gbuji teaches us that the supreme law is the salvation of souls – *salus animarum suprema lex* (Can. 1752). This law forbidding partisanship exists for that salvation. Therefore, as we celebrate this great founder, let us commit ourselves to a new model of engagement: Let us move from **Pulpit Politics to Formation Politics**. Let us be less interested in who becomes

governor, and more committed to forming credible Catholic lay men and women who, by their competence and integrity, will become governors or leaders at different levels.

Let our parishes become schools of Catholic Social Teaching, of voter education, of election monitoring. That is political engagement that is fully priestly and fully canonical. I therefore, charge this 38th Convention to promote deeper study, wider dissemination, and faithful observance of the CBCN's existing Policy on Clerical Partisan Politics, which remains the guiding norm for our priests and religious across all dioceses.

May the Holy Spirit guide our deliberations.

On behalf of the CBCN, I, hereby, declare this Convention open.

Thank you, and God bless the Church in Nigeria.

+ Most Rev. Ernest Obodo

Bishop Chairman for Canon Law, CBCN